INTERNATIONAL CYBERSECURITY AND DIGITAL FORENSICS ACADEMY

Crisis Communication & Stakeholder Management

GRC 105 Crisis Communication & Stakeholder Management

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1. On page incident communication plan

Suspected ransomware – unconfirmed

Incident start: Monday 08:15

Initial communication window: 08:30-12:30

Communication Objectives

1. Establish a single authoritative source of incident information.
2. Provide timely, accurate updates without speculating about cause, attacker identity, data exposure, or recovery.
3. Protect employees, customers, payroll operations, and organisational credibility.
4. Prevent further circulation of unverified information.
5. Maintain communication if corporate email, file sharing, or collaboration platforms become unavailable.

Command and approval structure

Role	Responsibility
Incident Commander	Owns incident decisions and approves technical facts
Communication Lead	Drafts, coordinates, distributes and tracks messages
IT/Security lead	Verifies system status, scope and containment
Legal counsel/ DPO	Reviews legal, privacy and disclosure obligations

HR/Payroll	Confirms workforce and payroll operational impact
Executive Sponsor	Approves strategic decisions and external commitments

Communication rule: No employee, department or spokesperson should independently issue incident statements on behalf of the organisation.

First four-hour communication

Time	Action/communication	Audience	Purpose
08:30	Incident Command Alignment	IC, security, legal, HR, communications	Confirm facts, designate spokespersons, impose disclosure hygiene
08:45	Employee holding statement	All Employee	Provide immediate instructions and address screenshot
09:30	Executive & Partner Briefing	Executives, key partners	Explain impact, risks, decisions and contingency planning
10:30	Employee Update	All employees	Share verified developments or confirm investigation continues
12:30	Four-hour Situation Update	Leadership and affected stakeholders	Review operational status, risks and next steps

Core messaging principles

- Accuracy before certainty: distinguish confirmed facts from unknowns.
- Transparency without speculation: acknowledge uncertainty directly.
- Empathy without false reassurance: recognise employee anxiety.
- Consistency: use approved wording across all channels.
- Accountability: communicate who is responsible for updates and when the next update will arrive.

2. Stakeholder Map / Matrix

Stakeholder Cohort	Primary Need	Message Owner	Requested Action	Update Cadence
Direct Workforce	Operational guidance + payroll stability reassurance without speculation	Comms Lead	Use designated channels only; do not forward screenshots	Holding now; next 14:00

Executive Leadership & Board	Fiduciary exposure, legal liabilities, decision triggers	Incident Commander	Approve resource allocation & external messaging thresholds	Briefing 10:00; review 14:00
Key Customers & B2B Clients	Service-continuity assurances & third-party risk status	Account / Relationship Lead (scripted)	No action required yet; monitor official updates	Only if impact confirmed; else 14:00 if needed
Regulatory Bodies & Legal Counsel	Precise, privilege-protected, auditable facts only	Legal Counsel + IC	Advise on any reporting obligation once facts verified	On demand / when threshold met
Banking & Payroll Clearing Partners	Cut-off milestones & technical data transaction boundaries	Payroll / Finance Lead + IC	Confirm alternative processing readiness if required	By 12:00 today if risk to Friday payroll

3. Holding Statement for Employees

08:30 Monday | Internal leadership and response team | Out-of-band conference call

Subject: Immediate Operational Notice – File Access Disruption

Dear Colleagues,

We are aware that several departments are currently unable to access shared files. Our IT and Security teams are actively investigating the disruption and are treating it as a serious operational incident.

At this stage, the cause, full scope, potential data impact and recovery timeline have not been confirmed. We understand that this disruption is particularly concerning because payroll processing is scheduled for Friday. Payroll continuity is being assessed as a priority; however, we cannot yet confirm whether processing will proceed as scheduled.

A screenshot is circulating in staff groups and beyond the organisation. Its authenticity and accuracy have not been verified. Please do not forward, repost, interpret or present it as confirmed information. Report where you received it to the designated incident contact without further distribution.

Do not attempt unauthorised troubleshooting, access affected systems through unusual links, or delete potentially relevant files or messages. Follow instructions from IT and your department lead.

Updates will be provided through approved alternative communication channels. Our next staff update is scheduled for **10:30 Monday**.

Thank you for your cooperation and patience.

4. A 100–150 word customer or partner update

Subject: Service Continuity Notice

We are currently investigating a disruption affecting internal file-sharing systems that began this morning. At this stage we have no confirmed information that customer-facing services or data have been impacted.

We are working to restore full internal capability and will communicate only verified facts. No customer action is required at this time. If any change to service continuity is confirmed, we will notify affected partners promptly through established channels.

Next scheduled status: 14:00 today (or earlier if material facts change). For any urgent operational query, please contact your usual relationship manager.

5. **A short executive briefing with current facts, unknowns, risks, decisions required, and next update time.**

Confirmed Facts

- Critical file share unavailable from 08:15 Monday.
- Multiple teams unable to access shared files.
- Security team preserving evidence and investigating.
- Payroll processing scheduled for Friday.
- Unverified screenshot circulating internally and externally.

Unknowns (must be verified before any further claim)

- Root cause, attacker identity, entry point, number of systems affected.
- Whether any data has been accessed, exfiltrated, or encrypted.
- Recovery time and impact on Friday payroll.
- Any regulatory reporting obligation.

Risks

- Uncontrolled external leakage of the screenshot damaging trust.
- Premature statements creating legal or contractual liability.
- Potential delay to Friday payroll if access is not restored or contingency activated.

Decisions Required Now

- Approve the internal holding statement and designated spokespersons.
- Confirm out-of-band channel and owner.
- Authorise Finance/Payroll to prepare contingency processing options by 12:00.

Next Update: 14:00 today (or immediately upon material change in confirmed facts).

6. **A channel resilience plan with a primary channel, fallback channel, owner and confirmation method**

Channel	Primary / Fallback	Owner	Confirmation Method
Secure out-of-band SMS / voice bridge	Primary (if corporate systems compromised)	Comms Lead	Read-receipt + verbal confirmation from IC

Pre-authenticated alternative email / Teams on clean device	Fallback	IT Security Liaison	Delivery confirmation + reply from designated recipients
In-person / phone cascade for critical roles	Tertiary	Department Heads	Call-back verification to Comms Lead

7. **A 250-word rationale explaining your escalation threshold and what you deliberately did not claim.**

The communication strategy prioritises timely acknowledgement while maintaining strict factual discipline. The initial outage is confirmed, but ransomware, its cause, the scope of affected systems, potential data exposure and recovery timeline remain unverified. Communicating these unknowns as established facts could mislead employees, customers and leadership, undermine organisational credibility, and create unnecessary legal or regulatory exposure.

The escalation threshold is based on materiality, urgency and potential harm. Any evidence of data exfiltration, broader infrastructure compromise, significant customer impact, payroll cut-off risk, or regulatory engagement must be escalated immediately to the Incident Commander, Legal Counsel and relevant executives. Routine status updates follow the established cadence, while material developments override scheduled communication times.

The employee statement acknowledges payroll anxiety without promising Friday payment. This is deliberate: payroll is scheduled for Friday, but operational feasibility has not been established. An unsupported assurance could damage trust more severely than a transparent admission of uncertainty. Employees are given actionable instructions, a reporting route and a definite next update.

The circulating screenshot is addressed without validating its contents or amplifying potentially harmful claims. Employees are instructed not to redistribute it and to report its source.

Out-of-band channels are prioritised because corporate collaboration infrastructure may be unavailable or compromised. Receipt confirmation and escalation procedures reduce the risk of critical instructions being missed.

External messaging is limited to relevant stakeholders and requires appropriate technical and legal review. This balances transparency with confidentiality and disclosure obligations.

The strategy deliberately avoids attacker attribution, claims of data theft, definitive ransomware confirmation, recovery promises and guarantees about payroll. Communication will evolve as evidence is verified, preserving trust through disciplined, accountable updates.

Critical Reflection

The central tension is the pressure to calm employee anxiety about Friday payroll against the legal and ethical duty not to issue unverified promises. The most difficult dilemma was whether to say “payroll will proceed as planned” or to withhold any guarantee. I chose the latter.

Tactically, the holding statement acknowledges the payroll schedule, states that no delay has been confirmed, and commits only to a factual update by 14:00. This reduces immediate panic without creating a false assurance that could later be contradicted. By isolating the screenshot as unverified and routing all updates through controlled channels, the response also limits external damage while the investigation continues. The approach accepts short-term discomfort in exchange for preserved organisational integrity.